

chemistry was totally within reason. I must have gone back to working, but I don't remember it. I figured this extreme manic-depressive episode was a one-off (or a two-off, thinking back to 2008).

But two days later, I bought . . . wait for it . . . a plane ticket to Europe.

Yes. You read that right. I spent the remaining money I had in my bank account, which was maybe \$800, on a nonstop flight to Paris on a boutique airline. I planned to go for two whole weeks. A coworker at *Thought Catalog* lived in Paris, and I thought I could lean on her for a place to stay for at least a couple days. (Had I asked her before booking? Of course not.) I also had a friend who lived and worked in Madrid, and I wanted to visit her. I thought, *The real reason I got sick is I am too stressed out. I deserve a vacation.* I was still panicked constantly, couldn't afford any more time off work, and certainly had no money to pay for accommodations or tourist attractions or food. So too soon after my mental breakdown, I had changed nothing about my lifestyle and was off on an impromptu expensive vacation.

In Europe, I slowly went more insane. I had done no research. I was not aware of the exchange rate, so I used that as an excuse to not understand how much I was spending. I was there by myself, so I visited all the landmarks alone, but it was hard to keep myself busy during the day. I had too much anxiety to talk to anyone, and my one friend in Paris was working because she was a person with an apartment and a boyfriend and, you know, a whole life that wasn't about me. I had not planned this trip at all. At night, to assuage my anxiety, I drank a lot. Then the next morning when I was sightseeing, I would feel sick. One day I took a train to Versailles and realized I had no money to eat while I was there, but it didn't matter because the combination of hangover and anxiety made me throw up on the lawn of the palace. I wrote in my journal for that day, "Do you think Marie Antoinette ever vomited here?"

I don't mean to seem ungrateful about spending time among the beauty of Europe. A highlight was meeting my grandmother's cousin and being able to take photos with him that my grandmother still cherishes. I also rode the train to